COVER STORY



VINCENT STECKLER, CEO

CIO Review 20 Most Promising CYBER SECURITY Solution Providers 2017 INDIA

AVAST SOFTWARE

ANDROID IS THE NEW TARGET: DEFENDING MOBILE USERS WORLDWIDE AGAINST HACKERS AND MALWARE

By Shaheen Saikia

Just as the industry leaders and CIOs were in the process of implementing new security measures following the WannaCry ransomware attack that affected more than 200,000 PCs in over 100 countries, another ransomware was spotted making its way around China during June-2017. However, this ransomware, which looked awfully similar to the WannaCry ransomware, differentiated itself as a ransomware that was attacking only Android smartphones and leveraged popular social media such as gaming groups, chat applications and more to proliferate and infect mobile devices across networks.

With over 2.3 billion smartphone users, we are now leaving digital footprints with our mobile devices more than ever. Strengthened by its deep penetration across geographies and convergence of different mediums, the utility of mobile devices have dramatically expanded from the individuals into enterprises. Businesses, in their attempt to realise the ultimate goal of anytime, anywhere access, are increasingly becoming mobile enabled and adopting a mobile first approach to their IT strategies. Hence securing these technological marvels should be a top priority for industry leaders and CIOs. However, on the contrary, what we have been witnessing is a continuous rise in the volume of mobile data breaches. From Timofonica to Hummingbad the complexity of these mobile infections have only magnified. With the global enterprise mobility market estimated

to be worth $140 Billion along with the global mobile workforce which is projected to reach $1.75 Billion by 2020, enterprises are not just battling against each other but also against mobile infections as well. Under the present circumstances, mere protection against cyberattacks isn't enough. The need of the hour are Mobile security systems that provide protection against new and unknown threats along with software updates, regular scans and backup of valuable information.

A key player in thwarting the proliferation of cyber threats worldwide is Avast Software. Carving out a new market, the Prague headquartered firm is one of the largest cyber security firms, protecting over 400 million users in across 150 countries from an estimated 3.5 billion attacks per month. An arch nemesis to cyber attackers, Avast was one among the few entities which were able to significantly minimize the further growth of the WannaCry Ransomware, detecting over 350 variants and blocking it over a million times. Vincent Steckler, CEO of Avast, divulging into the firm's mission tells us that Avast is dedicated to providing to the ever growing number of mobile phone users the perks of mobility while keeping their information safe and ensuring a worry free online experience.

Fighting Against Phishing and Theft

Avast has put forth a number of mobile solutions that completely secure the users' mobile device. Rated highest among the security apps on Google Play, Avast Mobile Security secures the users against the most common forms of cybercrimes- phishing and malware attacks. Compatible with the Android devices, the user-friendly and intuitive interface of the solution adds to the user's delight. Avast Mobile Security has been further optimised to provide an enhanced performance without draining out the device's battery strength.

Loss or theft of mobile devices is another major concern that users often struggle with. This has also been one of the leading causes that have led to several instances of data breach, owing to one of the primary functions of mobile devices today, which is to store critical data. Keeping this concern in view, Avast Mobile Security solution also features anti-theft capabilities that enable the retrieval of lost or stolen devices.

Using VPNs to Avoid Compromised Devices and Networks

Most of us often refrain from availing online banking services or going ahead with similar critical tasks when connected to an open Wi-Fi network. This concern stems from the fact that an open network could be a ground for compromised devices or an opportunity for the mal intentioned to sneak into our private space. Then there is also the possibility of the hotspot itself to be malicious. While most of us normally adhere to this warning, there is no denying that this significantly restricts our activities. Herein Avast comes into the picture with Avast SecureLineVPN for Android as well as iPhone users. A virtual private network solution, SecureLine connects users to the internet through secure Avast VPN servers and encrypts all the online activities and concentrates heavily on safeguarding information. The solution can be accessed anytime in all possible places such as hotels, airport lounges and more for protection against potential threats such as hackers as well as ISPs.

Working in close conjunction to Avast SecureLine VPN is Avast's solution for iPhone users called Avast SecureMe. It is a VPN app that also checks if the public network is genuine and secured to be connected with. The solution checks for vulnerable spots such as the strength of the passwords and router vulnerabilities, and alerts users before the phone connects to an unsecured network. Additionally, the solution alerts the user if anyone else is trying to connect to his/her Wi-Fi network.

Ensuring a Secure Environment for Data Exchange

With more and more organisations embracing BYOD (Bring Your Own Device) policies along with the movement towards enterprise mobility, critical organisational information is now at a greater risk of being compromised. Research by Avast revealed that nearly 80 percent of the companies enable employees to access corporate mobile apps on their own devices. More importantly, 72 percent of the companies cited datajacking as one of the greatest security challenges in relation to enterprise mobility. In line with the current trend towards enterprise mobility, Avast is spearheading modern enterprises, with Avast Virtual Mobile Platform. The solution differentiates itself from other solutions in the segment by taking an approach that focuses on securing data rather than devices. Avast VMP ensures that no data footprint is left behind on the device, thus preventing datajacking of the unsanctioned data on a mobile handset or computer from the data's primary owner. Moreover, the solution also enables users to make and receive encrypted calls and send instant messages without leaving a trace on their devices. The comprehensive policy engine further ensures greater security and control over apps, data and users, not only keeping the company's information safe but also keeping the privacy of the users intact.

Securing Passwords and Credentials

"Today, an individual has numerous password protected accounts online. Additionally, with the combination

of different types of characters, remembering passwords have become an extremely exhaustive task. At the same time it is also important to have strong passwords", opines Vincent Steckler. Keeping this concern in view, Avast has put forth yet another solution that eases all our lives. Avast's password management system called Avast Password which is available for both Android and iPhone users generates strong passwords, and auto fills the passwords as well as saves it while logging into any system, and automates the entire process.

Solutions Backed with a Powerful Security Engine

Avast uses next generation technology to create a clear distinction in the market with a state of the art cloud-based machine learning engine that empowers all the firm's cutting edge cybersecurity solutions. Providing an insight into this engine, the CEO divulges into its capabilities. Harnessing big data driven insights and artificial intelligence, Avast continuously enriches its knowledge and learning capabilities, comprehending threats in real time through the largest database of 400 million connected sensors from Avast's users distributed worldwide, making the engine smarter and faster. This wide coverage equips Avast to anticipate as well as tackle these threats before they surface.



Mahesh Khera,
Chief of Strategy and Business, International Sales (India)

The Future Roadmap: Keeping People online in India Secure

Avast's mobile security space is currently strengthened by a user base of over 185 Million users worldwide with an estimated 14.9 million users from India alone. Gearing up for more adventures ahead, Avast aims at making a greater impact securing emerging technologies such as IoT which at present accounts for 24.43 percent in the country. As this trend catches up, security challenges will only be amplified. The next cyber attack may hit us on a more personal level, affecting our day to day lives. However, Avast, equipped with the cutting edge technology, a vast user base and industry expertise to lead the domain, can soon be expected to be seen be at the forefront of IoT security space. The firm has already taken a step with Avast Wi-Fi Finder. The solution enables users to evaluate whether the other devices connected to the Wi-Fi network they are using are secure and also identifies any known vulnerabilities among these connected devices.

In a recent venture, Avast has also partnered with Aircel, a leading mobile network operator in India, to offer their mobile subscribers Avast Mobile Security and Avast Cleanup, as a part of the Aircel Protection Suite. Anupam Vasudev, Chief Marketing Officer- Aircel, is optimistic about the partnership and is positive that Aircel's smartphone subscribers will have a worry free experience, defended by Avast's extensive award-winning mobile threat detection network.

Additionally, as initiatives such as Digital India continue gaining momentum, mobile devices will continue penetrating deeper into remote areas of the country where there is a possibility that users may turn out to be technologically challenged. Avast also plans to dive into these regions detecting scams and associated malpractices while empowering the users. CR

Carrier Level Implementations

With mobile security products already tightly integrated with the four largest U.S. carriers, the firm is now in conversations with Indian carriers, to implement its family safety solutions that include Avast Controls and Insights (CnI) and an Avast Locator feature. Avast CnI will be instrumental in extending the capabilities of parents to protect their child from cyber bullying and stalking by alerting them against critical calls, texts, and chat messages sent to their children. A dedicated team in India has been looking into the partnerships in the market, and serving as contact for carriers. Key members of this team are Mahesh Khera- Chief of Strategy and Business, International Sales (India) and Ashok Agarwal -Head Operations, International Sales (India), who have been working closely with Kevin Ross- Head of International Sales and Global Business Development (U.S.)to get the products and solutions implemented. Furthermore, as a part of the Digital India project, the Government of India is in the process of introducing consumer safety and security services, which will soon require police patrol cars to reach the victim within 10-15 minutes after a panic button on mobile has been pushed. Supporting this idea, Avast Locator will enable the victim with this option to alert the police. Most importantly these implementations will be done at carrier level, as mobile security is stronger if installed at carrier level, it cannot be removed, and mobile security is much easier to adopt if it is built in and delivered directly to consumers by their carriers.